Back in the hotel room, Anirudhya thought how his position and that of the SIT's were not much different. Both were struggling for a lead that would launch them. He dialled the number of his IB contact in Madras who spied on the DMK's affairs and left a message. Someone knocked on the door. An overweight man in his thirties in a white safari suit stood there with a smile on his face. The golden watch on his wrist was prominent.

'Yes?' Anirudhya asked.

'I am Venu, sir. Superintendent of Police "Amith Berma" has sent me to give you this VHS tape, sir.'

His accent was thick. He handed Anirudhya the tape and left. It contained a film—*The Delta Force*. Intriguing. The doorbell rang again. Suddenly a slew of visitors, Anirudhya thought wrily. It was Verma.

'Hi! Busy?'

'So the VIP cop sent a pilot before landing up himself?' Anirudhya teased as he made way for his friend to come in.

'Say whatever you want to, but, man, I tell you the scene is crazy,' Verma said, throwing himself back on the hotel's king-size bed.

Anirudhya looked at his watch. It was 10.15 p.m.

'Drink?'

'No, man. I got to go back in twenty minutes. Let's have a quick bite instead?'

Anirudhya was slightly disappointed hearing that Verma had come for such a short time.

'So the film is to help me kill time?'

'Watch it.' Saying that, he got up and went to the bathroom.

India Today's reporters were entitled to spend if they had to entertain their sources. He took Verma to the Rain Tree restaurant in the hotel. The place was almost empty. Verma picked a corner table. Anirudhya asked for the drinks menu. In the conversation that followed, Verma agreed with the view that both the SIT and Anirudhya were in a similar situation—waiting for that one clue that would launch them in their mission. And Haribabu's ten photos seemed to be just that. The SIT had taken possession of the Chinon camera that had been found at the site and eventually secured the